example, eminent citizens such as Dr Ganesh Devy, Tushar Gandhi, Medha Patkar, Varsha Deshpande, Ulka Mahajan, Dhanaji Gurav, Chetan Shinde, Feroze Mithiborwala, Paromita Goswami, Dr Abhay Shukla, Lalit Babar, Irfan Engineer, Subhash Lomte and many others organized a number of meetings of eminent citizens in Mumbai, Pune, Wardha and other places in Maharashtra. The Wardha meeting to many of us was especially meaningful. After all, this was the sacred ground where Mahatma Gandhi and the Congress Working Committee spearheaded numerous programmes that changed India; and it continues to be a hotbed of political-social churning in Maharashtra's consciousness. We consciously borrowed from the Quit India resolution and made it our ideological glue. Points from it were also proposed as pledges (for ourselves and for the nation at large) for joining the Yatra. The first point was that the Bharat Jodo Yatra and everyone who joined it would be stand steadfast against fascism. Secondly, all those who joined the Yatra would be against 'Company Raj' (which we reinterpreted as crony capitalism). The third point, which we collectively asserted, was that Bharat Jodo did not belong to just one party—instead it was a mass movement that belonged to the people of India. The last point may seem counter-intuitive (especially given the Congress party itself was spearheading the Yatra), but the truth is that civil society was overwhelmingly wary of the Congress party's state leadership. Almost everyone personally knew many leaders, and found them to be conscientious and committed individuals. But as they say, there's many a slip between the cup and the lip. The bitter truth is that the bulk of Maharashtra's progressive forces decided to join the Yatra because they had faith in Rahul Gandhi, who had stayed true all these years despite the darkness and demons facing him. And even more importantly, all of us are patriots firmly committed to an India that remains secular, democratic, liberal and socialist. It was therefore on the basis of the three resolutions, an unspoken faith in Rahul and our love for India that we issued an appeal to all progressive forces in Maharashtra to join this dharma yatra.

To operationalize these pledges, we formed eleven civil society working groups, and coordinators volunteered to steer each group for discussions